9 ways to relieve hip pain quickly

by Stephen Huang, MD
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When you're living with hip pain that's impacting your quality of life, you want it to go away as soon as possible. With that in mind, let's dive into some of the most effective hip pain relief methods--from home remedies to therapies and treatments--to relieve hip pain quickly and get you back to doing the things you love.

What causes hip pain?

Hip pain can be caused by a variety of factors, ranging from injuries to chronic conditions. Understanding the root cause of your hip pain is the first step toward finding effective treatment and healing.

These are the three most common causes of hip pain:

- **Hip arthritis:** This typically affects people who are older and have done a lot of bending and squatting in their lives. Hip arthritis causes pain in the groin that radiates to the buttocks when walking or bearing weight. It's caused by degeneration of the cartilage in the joint.
- **Gluteal tendinitis (greater trochanteric bursitis):** This typically occurs in people who are older or who have gained weight recently. It's caused by recurring stress over the muscles and tendons on the side of the hip.
- **Acetabular labral tear:** This injury to the cartilage of the joint can occur after a trauma or fall in a younger person. It's common in gymnasts and other athletes.

How to get rid of hip pain quickly

From simple at-home remedies and stretches to more complex treatments, let's explore some of the most effective methods for relieving hip pain. Keep in mind that there is no one-size-fits-all approach to hip pain, so be sure and talk to your doctor about your individual needs.

1. Over-the-counter pain relievers

Over-the-counter (OTC) pain relievers can be an effective way to manage hip pain, especially when it's caused by inflammation, arthritis or muscle strain. Try over-the-counter medicine like ibuprofen, naproxen or acetaminophen. Be sure and ask your doctor before taking any new medications.

2. Ice

Try applying an ice pack to the affected area to reduce inflammation. Applying ice to relieve hip pain can be an effective and simple method for easing pain. Cold therapy works by constricting blood vessels, which helps to minimize swelling and numb the area, providing temporary pain relief.

3. Heat

You can also try heat to increase circulation. Using heat to relieve hip pain can be a soothing and effective approach, particularly for pain caused by muscle stiffness, tension or chronic conditions like arthritis. Heat therapy works by increasing blood flow to the affected area, helping relax tight muscles and improve your flexibility, which can reduce pain and discomfort.

4. Stretching

It can also help to try stretches of the gluteal muscles and tendons. As we age, our tissues become less pliable, or less elastic. Stretching your gluteal tendons can help improve the flexibility of the glutes and help treat tendonitis or bursitis on the side of the hip.

5. Physical therapy

Physical therapy can be helpful in strengthening your muscles, as well as increasing flexibility and function. Talk to your doctor about whether physical therapy is a good option for you.

6. Injections

We often use injections into the joint or bursa (the fluid-filled sac in your hip that acts as a cushion between bones) to reduce pain and inflammation. If you have arthritis and other pain relief methods haven't worked, your doctor may recommend injections.

7. Surgery

For severe cases of arthritis, sometimes surgery is needed to replace the surface of the joint with metal. This allows you to regain full range of motion and function.

8. Prescription medication

Medication is sometimes prescribed to reduce inflammation and pain, especially when over-the-counter options aren't providing enough relief. Stronger pain relievers are typically only used for a short period of time.

9. Alternative therapies

For some people, alternative therapies can be helpful in combination with medication and other medical therapies. Common alternative therapies for hip pain include chiropractic care, acupuncture and massage therapy. Consult your doctor about whether these therapies might be helpful for you.

Lifestyle changes to relieve hip pain

Making a few lifestyle changes can significantly help relieve hip pain and improve your mobility. Maintaining a healthy weight is crucial, as excess weight puts additional stress on the hip joints. Sometimes, surgery is only an option if you are at a certain weight. If you need support in losing weight, talk to your primary care doctor.

It's important to stay active, but be careful that you don't overdo it. Regular low-impact exercises like swimming, cycling or walking can strengthen the muscles around the hip and improve joint function without causing further strain.

When to talk to your doctor about hip pain

If your hip pain persists for more than a few weeks, worsens over time or interferes with daily activities like walking, sitting or sleeping, it's time to seek medical advice. Sudden, intense pain, especially following an injury, may indicate a fracture or other serious condition that requires immediate attention.

You don't have to live with hip pain. Talk to your doctor or find a doctor near you to help navigate your treatment options.

About the Author

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